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Faults and Traces

Some Stanford Ghost Stories

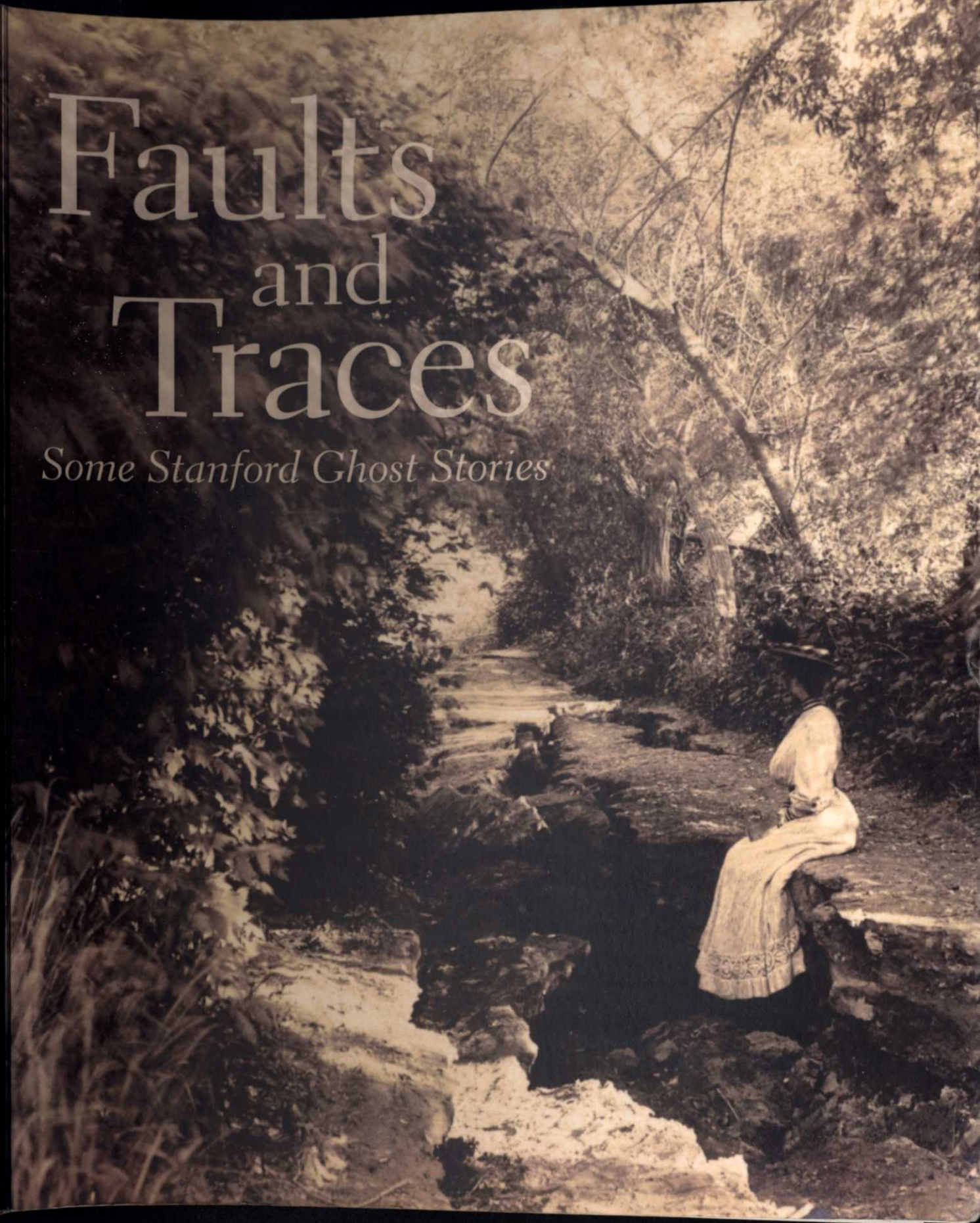




Figure 3
Rex Slinkard, *Portrait of Gladys Williams*, c. 1914–15; oil on canvas; Cantor Arts Center collection, bequest of Florence Williams, 1955.1030.

Into the Mystic: Rex Slinkard and Spells Cast

Conor Lauesen

He had the “prehistoric” outlook. His imagination worked somewhat like the minds of the ancients must have, when at eventide they looked upon the darkening woods, and peopled these with the creatures of phantasy. In fact, the entire trend of his art constitutes an ancient pantheism.

—E. Van Lier Ribbink,
“Open Minds Give Slinkard True Value”⁴³

Men’s curiosity searches past and future
And clings to the dimension. But to apprehend
The point of intersection of the timeless
With time, is an occupation for the saint—
No occupation either, but something given
And taken, in a lifetime’s death in love,
Ardour and selflessness and self-surrender.
For most of us, there is only the unattended
Moment, the moment in and out of time,
The distraction fit, lost in a shaft of sunlight,
The wild thyme unseen, or the winter lightning
Or the waterfall, or the music heard so deeply
That it is not heard at all, but you are the music
While the music lasts.

—T. S. Eliot, “The Dry Salvages”⁴⁴

Rex Slinkard was an American mystic. He was also an early twentieth-century painter, and in 1914 he began to paint one particularly chilling picture. The painting, *Portrait of Gladys Williams* (fig. 3), now in the permanent collection at Stanford in the Cantor Arts Center, shows Slinkard’s then-fiancée, a youthful Gladys Williams. Strangely, the young Slinkard and Williams both would die soon after the painting’s completion: the couple would never consummate their ill-fated marriage. Could one Slinkard painting know this future? How is the work brimming with haunted memory, perhaps activating unknown, bewitched curses throughout the beginning of the twentieth century? Was the portrait a kind of spell cast—a premonition of lives lost—by “poet-painter” Slinkard, himself an occult sorcerer and otherworldly conduit? The story of Slinkard’s incantations in paint, his prophetic mind and mystical imagination, and the spells configured within two paintings, *Portrait of Gladys Williams* and *Young Priest*, frame this art historical exploration. Slinkard’s quixotic life-story, and the legend of his poesis in paint, is where the tale begins.

Slinkard took part in a uniquely American dialogue: he was born into a dense genealogical history of spiritualism, transcendental presentiments, and philosophical contemplation. At the time of his death in 1918, *Los Angeles Times* art critic Arthur Miller noted, “He might have been the most sensitive

imaginative painter.⁴⁵ Growing up at the turn of the century in Southern California, Slinkard absorbed the ethos of frontier. American painter Marsden Hartley recollected Slinkard's metamorphic and preternatural sensibilities in a written memorial teeming with admiration for the young artist:

He felt everything joined together, shape to shape, by the harmonic insistence in life and in nature. A flower held a face, a face held a flowery substance for him. Bodies were young trees in bloom, and trees were lines of human loveliness. The body of the man, the body of the woman, beautiful male and female bodies, the ideal forms of everyone he encountered, he understood and made his own. They were all living radiances against the dropped curtain of the world.⁴⁶

Perhaps Slinkard's capacious imagination and revelatory wonder were indeed constitutive of a larger sensuous atmosphere blanketing early twentieth-century America. Art historian Bram Dijkstra wrote, "Slinkard's sensuous perceptions of the material world sets the stage for an understanding of the visual preoccupations of most of Southern California's independent modernists."⁴⁷ Specifically, the reverie of theosophical mysticism and the resonant shadows of American poets Walt Whitman and Ralph Waldo Emerson may help to situate both the historical origins of Slinkard's meditative disposition, as well as the visual strangeness of his paintings.

First, however, a brief inventory of those early war years: In 1914 the tragedy of global war began to plague the world landscape; Slinkard had stepped down from his position as director of the Art Students League

in Los Angeles the year before, and he commenced work on one of his master paintings, *Portrait of Gladys Williams*. On October 18, 1918—a mere three weeks before the conclusion of World War I—Slinkard died from influenza at St. Francis Hospital in New York City. He was thirty-one years old, enlisted in the United States Army, and waiting for his deployment to the European front. With his tragic 1918 death, he became a military statistic, one of the many distant deaths and liminal casualties of war. In Hartley's words, Slinkard served as a "representative of a generation lost . . . strong healthy beautiful lads" disappeared inside the American landscape of early twentieth-century warfare.⁴⁸ A visionary worldscape of fading ghosts and prophetic future shadows enfolded within this window of attenuated atmospheric time—just a four-year period spans the commencement of Slinkard's opus and his untimely death.

The early theosophical writings of mystic and writer C. W. Leadbeater seem to be part of an invisible synergistic dialogue with Slinkard's own mesmeric language in paint. Leadbeater's drawings, as well as his descriptions of auras and astral bodies, in his book *Theosophy: Man Visible and Invisible*, from 1902, echo throughout Slinkard's supernatural portraits. Leadbeater posited, "Every physical atom is floating in an astral sea—a sea of astral matter which surrounds it and fills every interstice in this physical matter. It is universally recognized that ether interpenetrates all known substances, the densest solid as well as the most rarefied gas."⁴⁹ The traces of these transcendent, "interpenetrating" visions are likewise ubiquitous in

Slinkard's oeuvre. Leadbeater further extrapolated the fluidity of organic life, myriad fluctuating molecules akin to a living fog: "Occult chemistry shows us another and higher condition than the gaseous, into which also all substances known to us can be translated or transmuted; and to that condition we have given the name of etheric."⁵⁰ I suggest we read *Portrait of Gladys Williams* as imbued with similarly bubbling vivacity and clairvoyant sensibilities: his painting is part and parcel with the miasmatic haze swarming to life in the alchemy of theosophy.

Consider also Slinkard's own passionately amorous night-vision—his sensuous temperament and intimate relationship with nature—in the following Whitmanesque musings in a letter to Williams:

Night, that I love like nothing else. I own air, night air that creeps down my breast and send[s] cool quivers over my skin . . . The night of air, that makes me feel like the breeze itself . . . The world's so large, mine, and all mine for tonight. What wonderful thoughts night has. They belong to the air—me thinks—breezes. How clean I feel. So unlike myself of the day. How sensitive I am. How everything is banished, but Beauty. The music of the night. I sing. I want to tell everybody everything. How wonderful I am—how wonderful the day makes me—but most wonderful the night.⁵¹

The great American transcendentalist Ralph Waldo Emerson similarly explored the horizons of imaginative vision and the mystical breath of the night. Emerson wrote this in his journal dated May 11, 1838:

Last night the moon rose behind four distinct pine-tree tops in the distant woods and the night at ten was so bright that walked abroad. But the sublime light of night is unsatisfying, provoking; it astonishes but explains not. Its charm floats, dances, disappears, comes and goes . . . I become a moist, cold element. "Nature grows over me." Frogs pipe; waters far off tinkle; dry leaves hiss; grass bends and rustles, and I have died out of the human world and come to feel strange, cold, aqueous, terraqueous, aerial, ethereal sympathy and existence. I sow the sun and moons for seeds.⁵²

Like Emerson before him, Slinkard was a visionary imbued with an acute sensitivity to darkening horizons, shifting spaces, and the winds of time. Art critic E. Van Lier Ribbink called Slinkard "a true mystic of the order of [poet William] Blake, [playwright Maurice] Maeterlinck, and [the German Romantic] Novalis." The 1914 painting of his fiancée is a correspondingly imaginative portrait, a dynamic representation of his young bride-to-be, a saturated haunting. *Portrait of Gladys Williams* is a conjured spell born of Slinkard's vertiginous imagination: it is a telescopic and visionary window into the microcosms and fragmented soil of paint—an ominous portent of the future.

Slinkard wrote to Williams, "The Great Ones are covered with snow. Wish you could see them. I like the open air, the clear air, the free air. The air between me and the snow mountains."⁵⁴ *The Great Ones*: Slinkard's term for the mammoth trees that festooned the landscape of his family's ranch in Southern California. The majestic trees were dynamic and enchanted in his mind. The poet Walt Whitman

painting's protagonist is also disturbingly absorbed, his eyes fixed on some eternally unreachable distance outside the pictorial frame. He appears mesmerized by something unavailable to viewers: a supernatural presence captures his attention, and his eyes elude direct contact. Slinkard the mystic is tranquilly withdrawn, his gaze focused on a shadow lurking somewhere beyond the painting. In some sense, Slinkard, the secular priest, is trapped: he is part of the painting, mummified in his own stillness. He is thus also a cool and calm conduit: his mind, the center of his own spiritual cauldron, is electrified on canvas. His dimly lit face remains opaque and distant while his head flames upward, bleeding into an oceanic mirage, the spewing aquatic fumes becoming a macabre fairy dust that glosses the landscape. The green hues that frame his face offer hints of chaos, the seeds of conjured spirits. Patchy neon swaths of peeled paint—electrified aquatic tendrils, dim vertical lacerations, and tiny, blossoming coral bubbles—mark the threshold between Slinkard's earthly body and the dizzying space behind.

Fading ghosts were in the air. Months before his death, Slinkard wrote to his friend and lover Carl Sprinchorn:

I wish you were here to see what I am painting. I wish you were here to see and say what you would think. You know there's a time when a fellow needs someone to say something. I'll tell you more about the Young Priest. Just finished another day of the Young P. I'm trying for rich colour, and trying to keep the painter out of it. That is, the brushwork, that attracts so many. And to get at facts in a simple way. To make one see this young man as he is, without regard for me. To make him a sad

young man. And a good one. Not too good. But good enough. The background is a large rich room with a suggestion of decorations on the walls and ceiling. And he is above, and the floor below . . . I'll paint different.⁵⁹

In the background, nightmarish dream-clouds of erased figures scour the atmosphere. On both edges of the painting, bracketing the central channel of verdant green, Slinkard introduces a tier of Duccioesque silhouettes in profile—yellow-robed half-figures that appear to be otherworldly, druid-like forms—a collection of sentinels guarding the sacred elixir permeating the priest's head. *Young Priest* offers a vision of Slinkard's death soon to come. Similar to *Portrait of Gladys Williams*, finished just a few years earlier, *Young Priest* beams with talismanic trembles and oracular spirits. Slinkard's musings to Sprinchorn are revelatory: "The old Florentines!—Giotto! Seem to interest me most. In him I find a reason, a moving reason, back of all. A before and after. A belief in something. I tell you Sprink, the world needs something finer than it's been getting of late years. Something the young men of our age can give. You, I am sure are one of the givers. After one's still-lives, landscapes, portraits, etc. there comes something else. That something interests me most."⁶⁰ Here Slinkard exposes not only the thoughts that animated his artworks but those that haunted young men of his generation, shrouded in the fog of war: disillusionment and the sense of insufficiency.

The priest's face suggests something palpably frightening, almost deathly: his widow's peak is like

dripping magma, his punchy red lips are beautiful, and his oversaturated orange face seems to nearly melt away. Disappearance and erasure echo throughout the canvas. Slinkard's priest is a boundary-crosser, a trickster suspended over the precipice between life and death; he is attuned to the ominous winds of 1917, to the tragedies percolating in both the global sphere and Slinkard's own life. *Young Priest* stands as the quintessential example of the artist's intimate and portentous hallucinations: it is an omen radiating a tragic malaise and divinatory pathos. Paint, canvas, and composition are indelibly interwoven, seemingly hyperconscious of Slinkard's disappearing self.

In one of the artist's final letters to Sprinchorn he mused on the sensuous night sky: "There's a new moon in an exquisite clear sky that is around with copper clouds, and one, and a few fleeting. There—and I stand and look into the heavens—in the cool fresh air I almost rise. I paint again for you. I am thinking of the universe." The otherworldly shimmer of night and the merging copper clouds anthropomorphically breathe in his universe. *Young Priest* similarly rises skyward within an analogous potion of fluid and blue atmosphere: the painting is a volcanic rupture. As a wounded cavity, the priest's body is airy, an ethereal vacuum; his silhouette is an inwardly curving incision. The central band forms a tree of life: the robed body as the trunk with a gossamer web of roots rippling along the painting's bottom edge; his head, the center of the hourglass shape; the patch-quilt bands of neon, the shadow limbs of dissolved budding branches. Slinkard's mysticism and morbid predilections lift

off: elevating vertically, the ecstatic blossoming of the priest's body reaches skyward, his flight visible only in the imagined mist beyond the painting's outer edges.

Coda

In 1955 Stanford alumna Florence Williams, older sister of Slinkard's onetime fiancée, Gladys, bequeathed to the university a collection of Slinkard's artworks—25 paintings and 176 drawings. Stanford's Cantor Center for Visual Arts quickly became the primary repository of Slinkard's works. Nearly one hundred years after Slinkard's untimely death, *Portrait of Gladys Williams* was on display as part of a 2011 Cantor exhibition entitled *The Legend of Rex Slinkard*.

NOTES

43. Charles C. Eldredge and Geneva M. Gano, *The Legend of Rex Slinkard* (Stanford, CA: Iris & B. Gerald Cantor Center for Visual Arts at Stanford University, 2011), 30. Ribbink was writing in the *San Francisco Examiner*, October 12, 1919.
44. T. S. Eliot, "The Dry Salvages," in *The Making of the American Essay*, ed. John D'Agata (Minneapolis: Graywolf Press, 2016), 251.
45. Eldredge and Gano, *The Legend of Rex Slinkard*, 31 (italics are Miller's).
46. *Ibid.*, 62.
47. Paul J. Karlstrom, *On the Edge of America: California Modernist Art, 1900–1950* (Berkeley: University of California Press, 1996), 162.
48. Marsden Hartley, *Adventures in the Arts: Informal Chapters on Painters, Vaudeville, and Poets* (Tucson, AZ: Hol Art Books, 2011), 87.
49. C. W. Leadbeater, *Man, Visible and Invisible: Examples of Different Types of Men as Seen by Means of Trained Clairvoyance* (Wheaton, IL: Quest Books, 2000), 12.
50. *Ibid.*, 8.
51. Slinkard to Gladys Williams, 1915, Slinkard Collection Object Files, Stanford University Archives.
52. Ralph Waldo Emerson journal entry, quoted in William Gass, *Habitations of the Word: Essays* (New York: Simon and Schuster, 1984), 14.
53. Eldredge and Gano, *The Legend of Rex Slinkard*, 31.
54. Slinkard to Williams (1915).
55. Walt Whitman, "Song of Myself," in *Leaves of Grass* (New York: self-published, 1855), 27.
56. Hartley, *Adventures in the Arts*, 87–88.
57. *Ibid.*
58. Eldredge and Gano, *The Legend of Rex Slinkard*, 55.
59. Slinkard to Carl Sprinchorn, January 1917, Slinkard Collection Object Files, Stanford University Archives.
60. Slinkard to Sprinchorn (January 1917).
61. *Ibid.*